companies to help the regime soften its persona. Jackson Bash and Jefferson Waterman International were paid exorbitant sums to polish the regime's image. The State Law and Order Protection Council officially became the State Peace and Development Council (SPDC) in 1997. A reshuffling within the power structure occurred with only the top four generals remaining in their current positions. During this same year, the regime gained admittance into the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN). Some regional experts believe the name change was done in part to help secure the ASEAN admission. It was also believed that this surface-level softening could enhance the tourism industry. The name change did not lead to any significant policy movement from the junta. This may have been a missed opportunity for Myanmar to open up internationally. For the junta, democracy was still in a long transitional phase, for which the generals would set the agenda and timeline.

THE NEVER-ENDING INSURGENCY PROBLEM

The junta had reasons to be worried. They faced internal opposition from the NLD and supporters (both domestically and internationally) of Aung San Suu Kyi, as well as the never-ending ethnic-based insurgencies. The tactics employed by the government would be to eradicate the insurgency problem by making separate ceasefire agreements with the different movements—a kind of divide-and-conquer strategy. Giving the key leaders either a certain level of autonomy or some sort financial incentive would help the regime achieve its goal.

Many student protesters from the initial pro-democracy movement had fled to the border areas to join in an alliance with the ethnic fighters opposing the government. It is estimated that between 8,000 and 10,000 persons fled the urban centers to join with the insurgency fighters. This coalition would be known as the Democratic Alliance of Burma (DAB). This was a noteworthy achievement because virtually every government since independence had demonized the ethnic populations as criminals and savages never to be trusted. SLORC's repressive policies had brought this unusual alliance together.

The coalition ran into numerous problems from the onset. Expectations were high that international assistance would be forthcoming. The